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MOHAMED MEETS BAHRAIN KING

■ President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan met Bahrain King Hamad Bin Isa Al Khalifa during a visit to the country. The two sides discussed the close ties and cooperation between the UAE and Bahrain, as well as ways to further strengthen relations in a manner that supports their development priorities and mutual interests and benefits their peoples. They also discussed developments in the Middle East and their serious implications for regional and international security and stability, as well as their impact on maritime security, energy supplies, and the global economy.

US NAVAL BLOCKADE ON IRAN SETS STAGE FOR SHOWDOWN

Trump warns boats near blockade to be ‘eliminated’

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump warned yesterday that any Iranian “fast attack boats” approaching a US-imposed naval blockade would be “immediately ELIMINATED”, escalating tensions despite international calls to preserve a fragile ceasefire.

The US military said the blockade — targeting all vessels entering or leaving Iranian ports — was set to begin at 1400GMT, though there was no immediate sign of enforcement as the deadline passed. US Central Command clarified that ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz to non-Iranian ports would not be impeded.

Trump, announcing the move after failed talks in Pakistan, said the blockade was aimed at forcing Tehran to reopen the vital Strait of Hormuz and accept a peace deal. “If any of Iran’s fast attack ships approach... they will be immediately eliminated,” he posted.

No port safe

Iran responded sharply, warning that “no port” in the region would be safe if its harbours were threatened, calling the blockade a “criminal act of

US STOCKS DOWN

Wall Street stocks retreated early yesterday as Washington’s naval blockade sent oil prices higher.

About 15 minutes into trading, the Dow Jones Industrial Average was down 0.8 per cent at 47,546.19.

The broad-based S&P 500 declined 0.3 per cent to 6,794.02, while the tech-rich Nasdaq Composite Index also shed 0.3 per cent to 22,826.38.

—AFP

piracy”. Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf said: “If you fight, we will fight.”

The standoff comes despite a two-week truce agreed last week to allow negotiations. Pakistan’s Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said the ceasefire was still holding, with “full efforts underway” to resolve outstanding issues.

The US leader’s latest change of tack left some observers perplexed. “Presumably, Trump’s intent is to try to starve Iran of export revenue and compel Iran’s main oil customers, particularly China, to pressure Tehran to end its blockade of the strait,” think tank The Soufan Center said in its daily note.

Nicole Grajewski, an assistant professor at Sciences Po’s Center for International Research, said a US blockade was “not a minor coercive signal” but could rather be considered an effective resumption of the war.

Restraint urged

Global powers urged restraint. The head of the International Maritime Organization, Arsenio Dominguez, stressed that no country could restrict “freedom of navigation” through international straits. Qatar’s Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed Bin Abdulrahman Al Thani warned against using maritime routes “as a tool for pressure”.

Britain and Spain distanced themselves from the blockade, with UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer saying London would not be “dragged in”. China also urged both sides to avoid reigniting the war.

The threats have already slowed shipping traffic in the strait, which had only partially resumed after the ceasefire.

With tensions rising and diplomacy faltering, the blockade sets the stage for a high-stakes confrontation that could upend global energy flows and unravel the fragile truce.

SEE ALSO P6, 8-10, 12-13

DP World ensures food supply isn’t hampered

CEO Al Hassan says there’s a clear hierarchy of needs, starting with food

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

DP World has been prioritising critical cargo, working closely with government entities, traders and manufacturers to keep imports moving even as traditional shipping patterns face pressure.

This is being done to make sure that supermarket shelves are stocked, with operators reworking supply chains to ensure food and essential goods continue to reach the UAE without disruption.

Ahmad Yousef Al Hassan, CEO and Managing Director of DP World GCC, said the approach has been structured around a clear hierarchy of needs, starting with food, pharma and agricultural inputs before moving to industrial supply chains that keep local production running.

“We work very closely with the government, especially a lot of the ministries, on the essen-

tial goods for the UAE. They fall into food and beverages, along with categories like milk, rice, animal feed and pharma,” he said.

750,000 TEUs of goods

Jebel Ali alone handled about 750,000 TEUs of essential goods last year, with roughly two-thirds tied to food and beverage shipments, providing a baseline for how much cargo needs to be protected during periods of disruption.

Instead of stockpiling, the focus has been on mapping demand and ensuring continuity of supply. Traders and manufacturers are being asked to identify their most critical imports, allowing DP World to prioritise cargo and route it through the fastest available channels.

“There’s enough essential goods, there’s no panic,” Al Hassan said, adding that the emphasis remains on keeping trade moving rather than building excess inventory.

That approach extends to sourcing as well. Where traditional suppliers face delays, alternative markets in India and Pakistan are being lined up, with feeder vessels used to move goods quickly into UAE ports.

SEE ALSO P4

TELL ME WHY



Dr (CA) Ankur Aggarwal, Founder and Chairman of BNW Developments, shares why he remains confident about the UAE property market



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NATION | P3

MONEY REIMAGINED



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